Types of Academic Sources – Peer-Reviewed, Scholarly, & Authoritative

Peer-Reviewed Sources

- Academic works (e.g., journal articles) evaluated by experts before publication.
- The peer-review process ensures credibility, accuracy, and scholarly quality.
- Commonly found in academic journals indexed in databases such as Scopus, PubMed, IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library.

Scholarly Sources

- Written by experts or researchers for an academic audience.
- Includes peer-reviewed journal articles, academic books, conference papers, theses.
- Key features:
    - Author credentials provided
    - References and citations included
    - Purpose is to inform, analyse, or report research—not entertain

Authoritative Sources

- Highly reliable sources produced by recognised, reputable organisations or experts.
- May not be peer-reviewed but are grounded in specialist knowledge, established methodology, or community-controlled governance.
- Examples include:
    - National peak bodies
    - Australian Indigenous community-controlled organisations
    - Government statistical agencies
    - Professional associations
- Used to support factual accuracy, policy relevance, and culturally grounded perspectives.

Key Difference (Overarching Statement)

All peer-reviewed sources are scholarly, and many scholarly sources are authoritative. However, not all scholarly or authoritative sources are peer-reviewed. Peer-reviewed sources undergo formal academic evaluation; scholarly sources are written by experts for academic purposes; authoritative sources are trusted because of the expertise, governance, or institutional credibility behind them.